COT & Midterm Context: NQ, Silver and the Rest

Prepared Fri Oct 30, 2026 (after the close) | Midterm election Tue Nov 3, 2026 | COT data: week ending Oct 27

Bottom line

- **Your rule (dashboard) says no COT edge on NQ, silver or gold this week.** The only index/metal-adjacent setup is BTC: Bearish (Commercials 12 vs hedge funds 100). EUR, GBP, NZD, crude and natgas show Bullish setups.
- **History says sharp NQ drops like this one usually see one more leg lower inside 4 weeks, then recover.** In 21 similar cases since 2007, 20 made a lower low within 20 trading days (median another -5.6%), but NQ was higher 60 days later in 16 of 21.
- **The closest analog is 2018, Trump's first midterm.** NQ was down about 6.5% from its high on election day after an October selloff. It fell another 19% into Christmas Eve, then was up 14.5% a year (52 weeks) after the election.
- **After every midterm since 2006, NQ and ES were higher 52 weeks later (gold and silver in 4 of 5), and silver and gold were higher 60 days later.** That's 5 cases, so treat it as a tailwind, not a signal.
- **NatGas is a Bullish setup on your dashboard, but history is a warning.** The two midterms with Commercials at an extreme long (2014, a full Bullish setup, and 2022 at 92) saw natgas lose about 46% over the next 52 weeks.
- **Silver is the closest asset to a Bullish COT setup.** Hedge funds (Managed Money) are at index 0, the bottom of their range. Commercials are at 62 and need 80. Watch next Friday's report.

1. WHERE THINGS STAND (VERIFIED PRICES, OANDA DAILY CLOSES)

Asset	Fri close	1 day	2 days	All-time high	Off ATH
NQ (NAS100)	28,410	-2.3%	-4.1%	31,401 (Oct 5, 2026)	-9.5%
ES (SPX500)	7,587	-1.3%	-1.9%	7,853 (Oct 5, 2026)	-3.4%
Gold	3,876	-3.6%	-4.7%	5,602 (Jan 28, 2026)	-30.8%
Silver	49.13	-5.8%	-9.0%	121.67 (Jan 28, 2026)	-59.6%
NatGas	2.606	-0.3%	-4.1%	6.01 (Jan 29, 2026, 52-wk high)	-56.6%
BTC	76,790	-2.5%	-5.5%	126,307 (Oct 2025)	-39.2%

NQ's high-to-low swing over the last two sessions was about 6.4% (30,045 on Tue to 28,111 on Fri); close to close it was 4.1%. Silver's Friday high-to-low was about 6.5%; close to close 5.8%. OANDA CFD closes at 5 PM ET, so they differ slightly from futures settlements.

Dashboard COT reads (your rule, governs the lean)

Asset	Commercial	Hedge funds	Non-Comm	Retail	Your rule	What would trigger a setup
NQ	28	86	69	75	No COT edge	Commercials to 20 or below = Bearish setup (others already 75-86)
ES	37	42	53	85	No COT edge	Commercials to 20 or below = Bearish setup (Retail at 85)
Gold	41	20	57	54	No COT edge	Commercials to 80+ = Bullish setup (hedge funds already at 20)
Silver	62	0	36	48	No COT edge	Commercials to 80+ = Bullish setup (hedge funds already at 0)
BTC	12	100	86	19	**Bearish setup**	Already on
NatGas	100	0	2	38	**Bullish setup**	Already on
US30	38	93	55	68	No COT edge	Commercials to 20 or below

Also on the dashboard this week: Bullish setups in EUR (C 90), GBP (C 88), NZD (C 91), Crude (C 93); no edge in JPY, USD, VIX.

Two COT views disagree on NQ and silver. The historical tables below use the CFTC Legacy report with a 70-week index, the only report that goes back to 1999 for all four markets. On that method, today reads NQ **Bearish setup** (Commercial 7, Non-Comm 90) and silver **Bullish setup** (Commercial 100, Non-Comm 0). Your chart panel shows the same NQ picture (Commercial 19). Per your call, the dashboard decides the lean; the Legacy view is context only. Both views agree BTC is a Bearish setup.

2. COT READS AND PRICE ACTION AT EVERY MIDTERM SINCE 2002

COT = Legacy report dated the Tuesday before the election (what traders knew on election day), 70-week index. Returns are from election-day close, in trading days. "Max dip 20d" = deepest low in the next 20 trading days vs the election-day close.

NQ (Nasdaq-100)

Midterm	President	COT C / Spec / Retail	Rule	Prior 20d	+5d	+20d	+60d	+52 wks	Max dip 20d
Nov 5, 2002	Bush (R)	99 / 10 / 26	Bullish					no price data before 2003	
Nov 7, 2006	Bush (R)	8 / 55 / 100	Bearish	+3.8	+2.1	+2.4	+2.3	+15.7	-1.2
Nov 2, 2010	Obama (D)	12 / 87 / 49	Bearish	+7.9	+0.1	-0.3	+7.1	+8.7	-3.8
Nov 4, 2014	Obama (D)	86 / 22 / 40	No edge	+2.6	+1.2	+4.0	0.0	+13.5	-0.3
Nov 6, 2018	**Trump (R)**	63 / 43 / 31	No edge	+3.1	-6.0	-4.9	-4.7	+14.5	-10.5
Nov 8, 2022	Biden (D)	92 / 11 / 42	Bullish	+0.1	+8.6	+6.3	+16.2	+43.6	-0.4

Silver

Midterm	President	COT C / Spec / Retail	Rule	Prior 20d	+5d	+20d	+60d	+52 wks	Max dip 20d
Nov 5, 2002	Bush (R)	82 / 9 / 70	Bullish					no price data before 2006	
Nov 7, 2006	Bush (R)	74 / 30 / 20	No edge	+10.8	+3.8	+12.7	+7.1	+9.8	0.0
Nov 2, 2010	Obama (D)	25 / 67 / 69	No edge	+7.1	+8.3	+7.4	+15.4	+56.5	-0.4
Nov 4, 2014	Obama (D)	86 / 11 / 49	Bullish	-11.7	+2.3	+7.0	+12.4	-2.4	-6.6
Nov 6, 2018	**Trump (R)**	75 / 20 / 82	No edge	+1.9	-3.0	-0.5	+10.2	+20.5	-4.6
Nov 8, 2022	Biden (D)	79 / 22 / 19	No edge	+10.7	+1.9	+7.9	+6.1	+6.0	-2.3

ES, gold and BTC at a glance (+60 days / +52 weeks after the election)

Midterm	ES COT C	ES +60d / +52w	Gold COT C	Gold +60d / +52w	BTC COT C	BTC +60d / +52w
2006 Bush	0 (Bearish)	+4.3 / +4.5	91 (Bullish)	+4.9 / +23.5	n/a	n/a
2010 Obama	90 (Bullish)	+8.1 / +4.4	20 (No edge)	+1.6 / +20.7	n/a	n/a
2014 Obama	61	-1.4 / +3.7	46	+12.6 / -3.2	n/a	n/a
2018 Trump	45	-3.9 / +9.7	81 (Bullish)	+7.6 / +21.5	2 (Bearish)	-47.0 / +41.7
2022 Biden	74	+10.3 / +17.7	95 (Bullish)	+9.3 / +14.0	64	+47.9 / +130.4

What the midterm history says

- **Post-midterm strength is real but small-sample.** NQ and ES were higher 52 weeks after all 5 midterms with price data, gold and silver after 4 of 5 (2014 was the exception for both); silver and gold were higher 60 days after all 5.
- **COT Bearish setups on NQ/ES at midterms didn't pay.** NQ was a Bearish setup in 2006 and 2010 and ES in 2006, and all three were higher 60 days and a year later. The seasonal tailwind overpowered the positioning read. That's another reason not to force a bearish NQ lean from the Legacy view right now.
- **COT Bullish setups at midterms did pay.** NQ 2022 (+16% in 60 days), gold 2006, 2018 and 2022 (all up 5-9% in 60 days), silver 2014 (+12%).
- **2018 is the exception, and it's the Trump analog.** An October selloff, a bounce into the vote, then a second leg: NQ fell from 7,200 on election day to 5,802 on Christmas Eve (-19.4%, -24.7% from the high), ES -17.7%. Metals barely dipped (silver -4.6%, gold -2.5%) and were up 10% and 8% two months later. BTC, a Bearish setup that week, lost 47% in 60 days.

3. HOW THE COT NUMBERS MOVED AFTER EACH MIDTERM

Same Legacy 70-week index. "C / R" = Commercial / Retail index the week before the vote, then 13 and 52 weeks later. Price change is from the election-day close (52 weeks = 260 trading days).

NQ

Midterm	C / R before	+4 wks	+13 wks	+26 wks	+52 wks	13 wks later C / R	52 wks later C / R
Now (Legacy)	**7 / 54**						
Now (dashboard)	28 / 75						
2002 Bush	99 / 26				no price data	93 / 0	68 / 24
2006 Bush	8 / 100	+2.4%	+1.6%	+8.4%	+15.7%	39 / 37	20 / 62
2010 Obama	12 / 49	-0.3%	+7.2%	+9.6%	+8.7%	13 / 40	52 / 0
2014 Obama	86 / 40	+4.0%	+2.0%	+7.4%	+13.5%	100 / 62	41 / 18
2018 Trump	63 / 31	-4.9%	-4.0%	+1.4%	+14.5%	100 / 14	13 / 44
2022 Biden	92 / 42	+6.3%	+13.8%	+23.2%	+43.6%	93 / 34	28 / 83

- **2006 and 2010 are the closest COT matches to today** (Commercials 8 and 12). NQ still gained 8-10% over six months and 9-16% over 52 weeks. Low Commercials going into a midterm did not lead to a decline.
- **2018 is the price analog.** Commercials started neutral (63). The December selloff flushed speculators, and by February 2019 Commercials were at 100 with speculators at 9: a Bullish setup that formed *after* the bottom. NQ was up 14.5% at 52 weeks, by which time Commercials were back down to 13.
- **NQ was higher 52 weeks after all five midterms.** By then Commercials were usually low again (13-52), as rallies matured. Big selloffs push Commercials toward 90-100 near the low; today they're at 7 (Legacy) or 28 (dashboard), so this selloff hasn't flushed anyone out yet.

Silver

Midterm	C / R before	+4 wks	+13 wks	+26 wks	+52 wks	13 wks later C / R	52 wks later C / R
Now (Legacy)	**100 / 22**						
Now (dashboard)	62 / 48						
2002 Bush	82 / 70				no price data	13 / 100	45 / 61
2006 Bush	74 / 20	+12.7%	+8.6%	+8.7%	+9.8%	56 / 31	45 / 79
2010 Obama	25 / 69	+7.4%	+10.6%	+50.2%	+56.5%	81 / 46	90 / 42
2014 Obama	86 / 49	+7.0%	+9.1%	+7.4%	-2.4%	0 / 40	0 / 21
2018 Trump	75 / 82	-0.5%	+7.6%	+2.2%	+20.5%	10 / 69	17 / 11
2022 Biden	79 / 19	+7.9%	+4.5%	+14.4%	+6.0%	39 / 49	37 / 62

- **Today's Legacy reading is the most bullish silver setup of any midterm since 2002** (Commercials 100, speculators 0). The closest matches, 2014 and 2022, rose 7-8% within four weeks, and silver was higher 13 weeks after every midterm with price data.
- **At 52 weeks the picture is mixed:** up in 4 of 5, but 2014, the closest COT match, was down 2.4% after Commercials flipped from 86 to 0 within 13 weeks and stayed there.
- **Commercials sold into each rally** (86 to 0 in 2014, 75 to 10 in 2018, 79 to 36 in 2022). A high reading usually unwinds within two to three months. The dashboard has Commercials at only 62, so your rule shows no setup yet.

Gold

Midterm	C / R before	+4 wks	+13 wks	+26 wks	+52 wks	13 wks later C / R	52 wks later C / R
Now (Legacy)	**74 / 51**						
Now (dashboard)	41 / 54						
2002 Bush	39 / 67				no price data	0 / 100	27 / 34
2006 Bush	91 / 40	+4.9%	+6.7%	+10.7%	+23.5%	58 / 72	2 / 70
2010 Obama	20 / 67	+1.9%	+2.9%	+5.9%	+20.7%	100 / 27	94 / 27
2014 Obama	46 / 21	+6.1%	+8.3%	+4.2%	-3.2%	0 / 100	21 / 70
2018 Trump	81 / 54	+0.8%	+6.5%	+4.4%	+21.5%	47 / 59	12 / 59
2022 Biden	95 / 7	+4.7%	+9.3%	+18.1%	+14.0%	52 / 44	25 / 47

- **Gold was up at 4, 13 and 26 weeks after all five midterms, and at 52 weeks in four of five** (+14% to +24%; 2014 was -3.2%). The high-Commercial years (2006, 2018, 2022) match today's Legacy 74 best; each time Commercials fell to about 50 within three months and to 2-25 by 52 weeks as speculators chased the rally.

ES

Midterm	C / R before	+4 wks	+13 wks	+26 wks	+52 wks	13 wks later C / R	52 wks later C / R
Now (Legacy)	**58 / 71**						
Now (dashboard)	37 / 85						
2002 Bush	51 / 60				no price data	64 / 57	59 / 31
2006 Bush	0 / 66	+1.9%	+3.6%	+8.7%	+4.5%	27 / 44	35 / 93
2010 Obama	90 / 70	+0.4%	+8.7%	+11.4%	+4.4%	53 / 50	100 / 70
2014 Obama	61 / 49	+2.6%	+1.7%	+4.4%	+3.7%	53 / 23	100 / 0
2018 Trump	45 / 31	-3.5%	-3.8%	-0.3%	+9.7%	96 / 32	72 / 27
2022 Biden	74 / 29	+4.9%	+9.1%	+9.9%	+17.7%	79 / 52	0 / 92

- **ES isn't at an extreme today; 2014 is the closest match** (61 / 49), a quiet, slightly positive year. **2018 is the warning case**: ES fell about 10% within 8 weeks, Commercials reached 96 only after the low, and ES was still up 9.7% at 52 weeks. ES was higher 52 weeks after all five midterms. ES retail is high today (71 Legacy, 85 dashboard).

NatGas

Midterm	C / R before	+4 wks	+13 wks	+26 wks	+52 wks	13 wks later C / R	52 wks later C / R
Now (Legacy)	**100 / 76**						
Now (dashboard)	100 / 38						
2002 Bush	20 / 69				no price data	11 / 68	87 / 77
2006 Bush	4 / 0	+7.4%	-4.1%	+3.3%	-15.6%	62 / 21	87 / 43
2010 Obama	43 / 14	+19.6%	+31.9%	+11.4%	+9.9%	77 / 98	35 / 5
2014 Obama	100 / 32	-10.5%	-37.8%	-31.6%	-45.8%	100 / 39	72 / 26
2018 Trump	1 / 95	+26.7%	-24.0%	-25.5%	-26.9%	15 / 86	92 / 35
2022 Biden	92 / 30	-1.3%	-52.7%	-59.2%	-46.4%	86 / 52	6 / 0

- **NatGas is the one market where midterm COT setups ran against the usual pattern.** The two extreme-long Commercial readings (2014: Commercials 100, specs 0, a full Bullish setup; 2022: Commercials 92, specs 31, so not a setup under your rule) were followed by losses of 46% at 52 weeks, and Commercials stayed at 82-100 for months while price kept falling.
- **The two Bearish setups worked, eventually.** 2006 (Commercials 4, specs 100) and 2018 (Commercials 1, specs 100) both spiked first (+7% and +27% within four weeks), then fell 16-27% by 52 weeks.
- **Today is a Bullish setup on both views** (Legacy 100 / 0, dashboard 100 / 0), the same shape as 2014 and 2022. One difference: Legacy retail is high (76) today, versus about 30 in both of those years. Winter weather drives natgas more than positioning does, so treat the COT setup as a lean for v7 signals only.

BTC (two midterms of data)

Midterm	C / R before	+4 wks	+13 wks	+26 wks	+52 wks	13 wks later C / R	52 wks later C / R
Now (Legacy)	**12 / 45**						
Now (dashboard)	12 / 19						
2018 Trump	2 / 0	-42.8%	-44.7%	-3.5%	+41.7%	82 / 38	76 / 43
2022 Biden	64 / 24	+6.1%	+37.8%	+70.3%	+130.4%	100 / 33	94 / 77

- **2018:** Commercials 2, speculators 100, a Bearish setup like today's. BTC fell 43% within four weeks, then was up 42% at 52 weeks after Commercials recovered to 76-82. **2022:** no setup; BTC was up 38% at 13 weeks and 130% at 52 weeks.

Summary. COT readings at 80+ or 20 and below usually moved back toward the middle within 8-13 weeks after a midterm, and often swung to the opposite extreme by 52 weeks. NQ and ES were higher 52 weeks after every midterm; gold and silver after 4 of 5. In metals, high Commercial readings before the vote were followed by gains over the next 13 weeks every time; silver and gold look like those years on Legacy, not yet on your dashboard. In NQ, low Commercial readings before the vote (2006, 2010) did not lead to declines; the one real drop (2018) began from neutral, and its Bullish setup formed after the bottom. NatGas is the exception: extreme-long Commercial readings at midterms failed badly. Each row is one election, five or six per asset: context for v7 signals, not predictions.

4. COT POSITIONING BY PRESIDENCY (LEGACY REPORT)

Term	NQ spec % OI	NQ price	ES price	Gold spec % OI	Gold price	Silver spec % OI	Silver price	Silver Bullish-setup weeks
Bush (R) 2001-09	-1.0	n/a	n/a	25.3	n/a	28.9	n/a	22%
Obama (D) 2009-17	15.4	+324%	+170%	31.9	+42%	21.1	+51%	20%
Trump 1st (R) 2017-21	8.7	+165%	+70%	32.6	+54%	18.4	+52%	20%
Biden (D) 2021-25	3.0	+61%	+57%	37.9	+47%	20.4	+19%	20%
Trump 2nd (R) 2025-now	8.0	+31%	+25%	**47.4**	+41%	26.4	+59%	**57%**

Spec % OI = average Non-Commercial net position as a share of open interest over the term. Price = term change (Trump 2nd through Oct 30, 2026). Setup weeks use your 80/20 rule on the Legacy 70-week index.

- **Gold speculators have been more crowded long under Trump's second term than under any other president** (47% of open interest on average vs 25-38% before). That crowding is what's unwinding now: gold is off 31% from January's high.
- **Silver has spent 57% of this term in a Legacy Bullish setup**, versus about 20% in every prior term, yet it's down 60% from its January peak. Commercials have been leaning long into a falling market for months. That's a reminder that a COT setup is a lean for v7 signals, not a timing tool.
- **NQ positioning is ordinary for a Trump term** (8% vs 8.7% in the first term). The crowding in NQ is concentrated in hedge funds (dashboard 86) and retail (75), not in the broad speculator group.
- Party or president, on its own, doesn't predict COT direction in this data. Every term had both setups. The useful part is the midterm calendar and the size of the current unwinds.

5. WHAT SHARP DROPS LIKE THIS HAVE LED TO

NQ: 2-day drop of 4%+ while 7-15% below the all-time high (21 cases, 2007-2026)

Horizon	Median	Average	Higher	Notes
+5 days	+0.5%	+0.5%	12 / 21	Coin flip through election week
+20 days	+3.0%	+1.7%	13 / 21	
+60 days	+6.7%	+5.4%	16 / 21	Losers: Nov 2007, Jan 2008, Oct 2018, Jan & Apr 2022 (bear markets)
Max dip next 20d	-5.6%	-6.4%	1 / 21 no new low	From 28,410, -5.6% is about 26,820, just under the 27,200 late-July low

Closest cases: **Oct 9, 2018** (Trump midterm, -9.4% off ATH): bounced 4.5% in a week, then -8% at 60 days. **Nov 11, 2018**, a week after that election: -1.9% at 20 days. **Mar 26, 2026**, this year's last one: +18% at 20 days.

Silver: 1-day drop of 5%+ while 40%+ below the all-time high (29 cases, 2008-2026)

Horizon	Median	Average	Higher	Notes
+5 days	+1.9%	+2.1%	19 / 29	Short bounce is the most common result
+20 days	+3.7%	+3.1%	17 / 28	
+60 days	+2.6%	+4.0%	15 / 27	Close to a coin flip
Max dip next 20d	-7.0%	-8.6%	0 / 29 no new low	Every case made a lower low; -7% from 49.13 is about 45.70

2026 is a falling market for silver. This year's earlier drops of this kind (Jun 4, Sep 9, Oct 13) saw further lows of 8-18% within 20 days, and the Jun and Sep cases were still lower 20 days later. Bounces have been sold all year, so the long-run averages above probably flatter the current setup.

6. DAYS AND WEEKS AHEAD

When	NQ	Silver
Mon-Tue Nov 2-3 (trade plan window,	No COT edge; trade v7 on its own. History is a coin flip for the next 5 days. Election-night gaps are possible.	No COT edge. A short bounce is the most common 5-day result, but every analog made a lower low within 4 weeks.

election day)		
Fri Nov 6 (COT for Nov 3, election day)	Key check: if dashboard Commercials drop to 20 or below with hedge funds/retail still 75+, NQ becomes a Bearish setup.	Key check: if Commercials rise to 80+ with hedge funds still near 0, silver becomes a Bullish setup.
Next 2-4 weeks	Base case from history: one more push lower (median -5.6%, around 26,800-27,200), then recovery. 2018 path (another -19%) is the bad case.	Base case: lower low first (around 45-46), then 60-day odds near even. Midterm history (5/5 up at 60 days) is the tailwind; 2026's downtrend is the headwind.
Into year-end	60 days later NQ was up in 16 of 21 drop cases and all 5 midterms. Losers were bear markets.	Gold and silver were up 60 days after all 5 midterms; gold COT Bullish setups at midterms all worked.

> **Limits.** Midterm samples are 5-6 elections, and the drop studies overlap with each other and with crises (2008, 2020, 2022). The Legacy 70-week index here is not the dashboard's calculation, which is why the Commercial numbers differ (NQ 7 vs 28, silver 100 vs 62). The dashboard governs the lean. This is historical context for your own rules, not a forecast or advice to trade.

Sources: CFTC Legacy Futures-Only COT (publicreporting.cftc.gov, NQ 209742, ES 13874A, gold 088691, silver 084691, BTC 133741, natgas 023651), dashboard values from COT_Breakdown_2026-10-27.pdf, OANDA daily mid closes (NAS100, SPX500, XAU, XAG, BTC, NATGAS). Scripts: midterm_cot_fetch.py and midterm_cot_analyze.py (repo root).